

- To win acceptance for a new idea, plan, or system (e.g., to explain the benefits of a new scheme to convince others)

Meetings can serve many other purposes. For example, they can be used to build morale, confer awards or recognition, plan projects and strategies, or provide training to employees, suppliers, and customers. The common denominator in any meeting is the group. If there is a clear need for a group of people to assemble, a meeting is called for.

Preparation

Before you call a meeting, ask yourself the following questions:

- Is this meeting necessary?
- What is my objective?
- Is the timing right?
- How much will the meeting cost?

If you have decided to call a meeting, then determine the following:

- Time
- Duration
- Meeting notice and agenda
- Participants
- Venue and set-up

Time

If a meeting is initiated by a crisis or an emergency, there may not be much choice in terms of scheduling. However, whenever possible, carefully consider the timing of a meeting because it can have a significant impact on the outcome. Given below are some scheduling guidelines:

- Choose a time during which participants are at their best.
Do not call a meeting on Monday mornings or Friday afternoons when participants are likely to have little motivation. Do not schedule a meeting for the hour immediately after lunch when most people feel lethargic.
- Start at an unusual time and end at a natural break point.
There is no law that says a meeting must start on the hour or half hour. If you select an unusual starting time, participants are more likely to show up punctually, especially if the meeting is scheduled to end at a natural break point, such as lunch or the close of the workday.
- Allow ample time for preparation.
Make sure that participants have sufficient time to prepare. This will vary according to the nature of the meeting. The longer or more involved the meeting, the more the time required to prepare the related materials.
- Avoid surprise meetings.
Nobody appreciates a surprise meeting. On-the-spot meetings interrupt the flow of the workday and allow people insufficient time to prepare, resulting in most participants entering the meeting room with a negative attitude.

The Four Ws

Successful, constructive meetings take place as a result of careful preparation. When preparing for a meeting, keep these crucial aims always in mind.

- Why is the meeting being held?
- Who should be present?
- Where should the meeting be held?
- When should the meeting take place?

Duration

The appropriate length for a meeting depends on the type of meeting and on the number, complexity, and sensitivity of the agenda items. The more complex or controversial the items, the fewer that can be addressed in a given time period. If there are more topics than can be effectively covered in a single meeting, schedule a second meeting rather than trying to cram too much information into the first.

The greater the number of participants, the shorter the meeting should be. In a small meeting, a higher level of interaction is possible. In a large meeting, interaction is restricted, and it is more difficult to maintain interest. Five people working on a problem may be absorbed for hours, five hundred people listening to a lecture can become distracted within minutes. When scheduling long meetings, allow sufficient time for breaks. For all-day meetings, allow at least an hour for lunch, but preferably an hour and a half or two hours. This gives participants time to recover from post-lunch fatigue and ensures more productive afternoon sessions.

Meeting notice and agenda

An agenda is the list of individual items that ensure that the meeting achieves its broad aims.

It is important to inform the participants well in advance about the meeting so that they can attend and contribute significantly to the meeting. This can be done by the following:

- Circulating a printed notice
- Sending an email
- Informing participants over telephone

Few traditional organizations still follow the old method of circulating a printed notice and getting the signature of all participants, but the other two methods are widely followed today. When a meeting requires only internal participants, they can be informed through internal telephone lines. However, we must ensure that somebody at the other end receives the information if the particular person is not available at that time. Circulating the information by email is the other alternative. Any notice needs to include the following details:

- Date on which the notice is sent
- Details regarding the purpose (why); date, day, time (when); venue (where) of the meeting
- List of agenda items (what business is to be transacted)
- Signature
- Recipients (who)

'To get something done, a committee should consist of no more than three men, two of whom are absent.'

—Robert Copeland

A written agenda, which is the list of the individual items that need to be discussed in the meeting, should also be included with the notice. It is the single best predictor of a successful meeting. The agenda keeps the meeting on course and helps to ensure that the stated objectives are accomplished. It also serves as a planning tool for participants and a control tool for the leader. With the meeting objectives clearly defined, an agenda can be developed, keeping the following guidelines in mind:

- Limit the number of agenda items.

Focus on a few critical items—three to six is a good rule of thumb. Separate the 'need to know' from the 'nice to know' and include only the former. The remaining topics can be summarized and included with the agenda as supplementary material or held back for a future meeting. Also determine the order in which items will be discussed, arranging them logically.

- Do not dwell on the past.

If a meeting is to be productive, it must focus on actions and decisions that will affect the future. The meeting agenda should reflect this future orientation.

- Present opportunities, not problems.

Keep the agenda upbeat. Instead of focusing on problems, recast them as opportunities. Every problem represents an opportunity of some kind—to improve a process or prevent a future problem, for example. If a problem is presented in this light, there is a better chance that it will be resolved.

- Allocate ample time.

An agenda should be well-organized, but not so rigid that it inhibits creativity or discourages full participation. Allocate some extra time for questions, creative discussion, etc.

- Include sufficient detail.

An agenda item should give participants the specific information they need in order to prepare for the meeting. It should enable them to understand exactly what is to be accomplished. For example, the agenda item 'advertising budget' may receive a more positive response if put across as 'allocate the advertising budget among direct mail, print, radio, and television'. With this level of information, participants can gather the appropriate data for the meeting and prepare their arguments for or against each advertising medium.

- Include the following details in an agenda: name of the organization, department/committee; first or follow-up meeting (this helps in maintaining a record); date, time, venue; items to be discussed
- If possible, email the agenda along with the meeting notice to participants a week before the meeting. The more the preparation required for the meeting, the earlier the agenda should be sent out.
- If the agenda has less number of items, it can be included in the meeting notice itself. Otherwise, the agenda has to be circulated separately.

Exhibit 9.1 is a sample meeting notice that includes an agenda containing five items.

EXHIBIT 9.1 Sample meeting notice and agenda

Jupiter Group of Hotels Management Committee

23 March 2015

You are invited to attend the fifth meeting of the Management Committee of Jupiter Group of Hotels to be held at 6 p.m. on Wednesday, 29 March 2015, in the Venus Hall, 58, Park Avenue, New Delhi-110 005.

Agenda

- 5.01 Minutes of the last meeting
- 5.02 Recruitment of management trainees
- 5.03 Opening a branch in Nagpur
- 5.04 Innovations in travel packages
- 5.05 Any other matter

(Vivek Pai)
Secretary

TABLE 9.4 Optimal meeting size

Meeting type	Maximum no. of participants
Problem solving	3–5
Decision-making	6–10
Problem identification	6–10
Informational	20–30
Review or presentation	20–30
Motivational	No limit

Identify the Right People to Attend a Meeting

- Those who have enough knowledge of the subject to make a meaningful contribution to the meeting
- Those with the power to take decisions or approve projects
- Those responsible for implementing decisions made in the meeting
- Those who will be affected by the decisions made, or their representatives

Participants

One of the primary causes of unproductive meetings is not having the right people in attendance. An invitation to a meeting should always be based on purpose rather than on politics. In addition to inviting the right people, it is important to invite the right/optimum number according to the type of meeting. See Table 9.4.

Venue and set-up

‘Where’ people meet is as crucial as ‘why’ and ‘when’. The choice of a meeting room has a significant impact on the overall quality of the meeting. Among other things, a meeting room can enhance or inhibit productivity, encourage or discourage communication, promote or stifle creativity, and make participants feel relaxed or tense. As the meeting room plays such an important role in meeting productivity, it is important to take great care in its selection and set-up. The following aspects of a conference room need to be considered in this regard:

- Size
- Lighting
- Ventilation
- Acoustics
- Electrical outlets
- Storage space
- Chairs
- Sound system
- Distractions
- Presentation equipment
- Projection screens
- Other amenities
- Special needs

Once the venue is decided, whether it is within the company premises or outside, it must be reserved early enough. In case the selected venue is not available, locate a similar site or consider postponing the meeting. The type of meeting affects not only the choice of the meeting room but also how it is set. Given below are some suggested layouts to improve access, heighten interaction, and increase visual contact:

Boardroom style This style is suitable for most meetings that involve sitting around a table. See Figure 9.1.

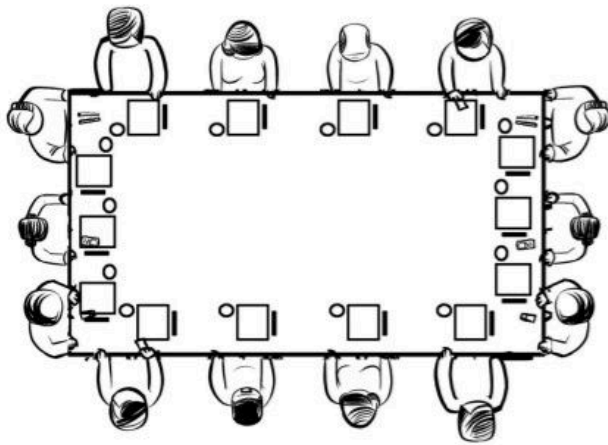


FIGURE 9.1 Boardroom style seating

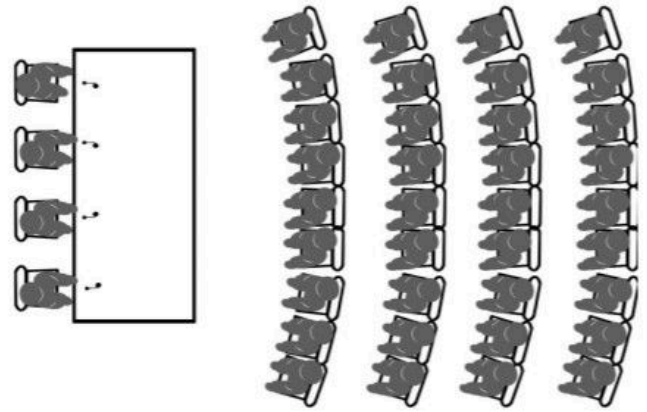


FIGURE 9.2 Conference style seating

Conference or theatre style This style is suitable for annual general body meetings, or any other meetings that involve a large number of participants, presentation, and a question-and-answer session. See Figure 9.2.

A less formal layout is more appropriate for informal meetings. Consider eliminating tables altogether and sitting 'in the round'. However, please remember to provide some form of surface for placing laptops or notebooks for the participants and the person taking down the minutes. A popular form of current office layout is to have a 'teardrop' (Figure. 9.3) end to a standard desk around which two or three chairs can be placed, providing the meeting area.

Procedure—Conducting Effective Meetings

The quality of a meeting is largely determined by how well the players act out their roles. By playing the three primary roles of leader, facilitator, and participant, the chairperson can direct the meeting towards achieving its specified goal. Listed below are the responsibilities of the chairperson towards making a meeting effective:

- Getting the meeting off to a good start
- Managing conflict
- Encouraging participation
- Injecting humour
- Drawing silent types into the discussion
- Ending the meeting
- Joining the discussion
- Preparing and finalizing the minutes
- Managing emotions
- Evaluating the meeting
- Dealing with latecomers



FIGURE 9.3 Teardrop extension to the meeting table

Getting the meeting off to a good start The chairperson/leader must establish control of the meeting from the start by setting the tone and stating the ground rules and objectives. A brief orientation speech by the chairperson can get rid of the needless talk that typically occurs at the

T-1-s Approach to Introductions

1. Introduce the Topic the speaker will address.
2. Clarify why the topic is of Interest or value to the group present at the meeting.
3. Explain why the Speaker is qualified to address this topic.

start of the meeting. The chairperson must set up the meeting, state the problems and the general objectives and procedures, provide the relevant information base for the discussion, and note the boundaries and constraints of the discussion.

Encouraging participation Encouraging participation is one of the leader's main obligations. Unfortunately, not all meeting leaders know how to go about this. Here are some tips for encouraging participation in a meeting:

- Do not monopolize the discussion.
- Do not exhibit verbal or non-verbal disapproval of ideas even if you disagree with them.
- Ask open-ended questions to stimulate discussion.
- Frame problems in positive terms (e.g., 'How can we achieve our goal?' rather than 'Is it possible to achieve our goal?').
- Identify the introverts and make a point of asking for their input.
- Do not let extroverts monopolize the discussion.
- Control participation by reminding people of the purpose of the meeting and by bringing discussions to a meaningful end. Sometimes, it is necessary to remind participants of the time, so that we can move on to the next topic.
- Recognize differences in individual styles.
- Change the seating arrangement (based on the previous experience).
- Rotate leadership.

Drawing silent types into the discussion Silence can be divided into three categories:

- Silence of general agreement and no contribution
- Silence of diffidence
- Silence of hostility

Among these three categories, the first type is not of much concern; however, the other two may be a cause for disquiet. In the case of diffidence, the leader should gently bring the participant into the discussion and make it clear that the person's input is valuable. The silence of hostility signals that a person is detached from the whole proceedings and usually indicates that the person is experiencing some feeling of disrespect or humiliation. The chairman should try to get to the root of the problem and encourage participation.

Joining the discussion In most cases, it is better for the leader to stay out of the discussion and remain in the neutral, facilitative role. If the leader wants to advocate a point, it is best for him or her to do so later in the discussion, when others have introduced the point, so as not to unduly influence the group's thinking. However, there is an exception: if the leader has relevant knowledge or experience, the group may feel the leader is obliged to share it with them. He/she cannot remain aloof from the proceedings as an impartial moderator, but can show himself/herself to be a fair-minded, even-handed participant who contributes significantly for the common good.

'Where all think alike, then
no one thinks very much.'

—Walter Lippmann

Managing emotions The meeting leader should be conscious of not only the written agenda of the meeting but also the hidden and emotional agenda of the participants. The term 'hidden agenda' refers to the unspoken motives and aspirations of the group members, which could often conflict with the main goals of the group. Hidden agenda indicates what people really want as against what they say they want.

The leader should realize that meetings also have the goal of creating and maintaining positive emotions that promote working together effectively. This does not mean that the leader should ignore negative emotions. A person's anger over a budget cut, for example, may be a legitimate expression of concern. By exploring the reasons behind the anger, the leader can work with the group to address the problem productively. Acknowledging the existence of these emotions and creating trust will help people voice their concerns more openly. Apart from recognizing obvious displays of emotion, the leader must also be alert to subtle signs of emotional distress, using his own feelings as a guide.

Dealing with latecomers The only way to ensure that a meeting starts on time is to start it on time. In addition, the leader should try to find out why certain people are habitual latecomers. He/she should make them realize their importance and their valuable contribution to the meeting. If people feel important and can anticipate achievement, they will be motivated to come on time.

Managing conflict Some conflict is inevitable when people with varying views meet. This is not necessarily a negative feature. In fact, it is a mistake to discourage conflict because it can improve the quality of decisions, and stimulate creativity and innovation. Controversy promotes objectivity and enquiry, and enables thorough discussion and effective problem solving. The best solutions and plans often develop from contrary points of view within the meeting group. Of course, not all conflict is productive. Whether a given conflict is constructive or destructive depends on how skilfully the meeting leader manages it.

Injecting humour One effective way to dissolve tension in a meeting is to reframe a problem or conflict in a humorous light. Humour can be a valuable asset in many meeting situations. For example, humour can be used to help put people at ease, make bad news easier to accept, or introduce a sensitive subject. Personal anecdotes about funny, embarrassing, or ironic events that happened in college, on the job, etc. are a good source of humour. They often work better than jokes because the fact that they are real gives them added impact. In addition to using humour, it is important for the leader to acknowledge others' appropriate use of humour, and to discourage inappropriate jokes.

It is a good idea to close on a positive note.

Ending the meeting When all items on the agenda have been covered, it is time to bring the meeting to a close, whether or not the scheduled



Tips to Manage Conflict

- Make it clear at the start of the meeting that it is fine to challenge ideas but that personal attacks will not be accepted.
- Make strategic seating arrangements. For example, the place to put a domineering individual is near the leader.
- Observe silence for a while if someone in the group becomes aggressive.
- Give an assignment (the bigger the better) to the participant who plays devil's advocate by continuously challenging everything the leader or other group members say.

time has run out. While closing the meeting, the leader should sum up what has been accomplished and what remains to be done. He/she should recapitulate what action is expected of each participant. If another meeting on the subject is to be scheduled, the leader should set a tentative date and time. Even if the group has not reached an agreement, solved a problem, or met some other objective, the meeting leader can acknowledge any progress that has been made. This sets a positive tone for future meetings and helps to impart a feeling of control.

Minutes are a record of what happened at a meeting.

Preparing and finalizing the minutes Traditionally, after the meeting is over, the secretary works on the minutes of the meeting. Minutes are a record of what happened at a meeting. They serve as a useful tool to remind the participants of the actions that need to be taken, show the process of arriving at certain decisions, and also serve as a repository of information for future reference.

In general, the secretary takes notes during the meeting and then prepares the minutes to be read out and signed by the chairperson during the next meeting. However, the recent trend is towards managers who chair the meeting themselves preparing the minutes. Also, since participants most often have access to laptops, the information can be keyed in as and when points are raised and decisions are taken. After the meeting gets over, a fair copy of the minutes is prepared, with the contents arranged in an appropriate format. This is then circulated among the attendees in order to receive any comment. Once the comments are received, they are verified and the minutes are given a final shape by the Chairperson. It is these 'minutes' that are read as the first item of the agenda for the next meeting.

Minutes can be classified into two types and various styles as shown in Table 9.5. Depending upon the style, formal minutes contain the following information:

- *Minimal* The bare minimum of information, such as when and where the meeting was held and the decision arrived at
- *Medium* A précis of what was said at the meeting in the form of a structured report
- *Verbatim* A word-for-word account of what was said

Similarly, informal minutes contain the following details:

- A bullet point list of the decisions taken and the work progress to date
- A list in tabular format, giving the topic, the decisions made or progress to date, and subsequent action items
- A narrative report of a conversation that took place between several people

While preparing the minutes of a meeting as the chairperson/leader, it may be useful to check whether we have the following:

- A list of participants
- A copy of the agenda and all the accompanying papers
- A copy of any formal resolutions being proposed
- A copy of any presentations being given
- Two copies of the minutes of the last meeting, one for signature and the other for writing down amendments, if any
- Copies of any suggested amendments already received
- Notes of apology for missing the meeting from any participants
- A diary and a list of dates for future meetings

TABLE 9.5 Minutes—formal and informal

Formal minutes	Informal minutes
• Minimal	• Bullet point list
• Medium	• Table format
• Verbatim	• Narrative report

When putting together the minutes, we must ensure that we do the following:

- Draft the fair copy of minutes within a week from the date of the meeting.
- Decide the style of the minutes and prepare a template with all the headings.
- Keep a list of all the abbreviations and acronyms used and make a glossary of all these at the end of the document.
- Make an action point list, noting down all the things that were agreed upon, who is to do them, and any deadlines agreed upon.
- Make a note of all the items participants agreed to discuss at the next meeting and pass this on to the chair or committee secretary to include in the next agenda.
- Circulate the minutes to all the attendees for their comments; give them a deadline to send in their comments if they have any.
- Make necessary changes after verifying the comments.

Although we have mentioned the different styles for recording the minutes of a meeting, Exhibits 9.2 and 9.3 show the most commonly followed styles.

EXHIBIT 9.2 Sample minutes in the formal style

Jupiter Group of Hotels Management Committee		
Minutes of the fifth meeting held at 6.00 p.m. on Wednesday 16 April 2015, in Venus Hall, 58, Park Avenue, New Delhi-110 005		
Present: Rakesh Chawla (President) Navneet Arora (Vice President) Vivek Pai (Secretary) Lakshmi Deshpande (Joint Secretary) Sunil Kishore (Treasurer) Amritha Saxena (member)		
Absent: Narasimha Rao (member)		
No. of Minutes	Subject	Details of Discussion
5.01	Minutes of last meeting	Minutes from March 10, 2015 meeting were read, approved and signed by the the president.
5.02	Recruitment of management trainees	Navneet Arora stressed the need for recruiting five management trainees, 2 for the Delhi branch and 3 for the Bengaluru Branch. The committee discussed the matter at length. It approved the idea and decided that the secretary will place the advertisement in all leading details within a week.
5.03	Opening a branch in Nagpur	Lakshmi Deshpande presented the findings of survey conducted in Nagpur and opined that there is no need for a branch in Nagpur. The committee unanimously agreed with her.
5.04	Innovations in travel packages	Rakesh Chawla proposed that certain innovations in the travel packages for this summer will promote revenue arising out of tourism. The committee discussed the issue; a three-member committee consisting of Vivek Pai, Lakshmi Deshpande and Sunil Kishore was formed and was asked to work out on this matter and report to Rakesh Chawla latest by 25 April 2015.
5.05	Complaints regarding room service	Navneet Arora expressed great concern over the complaints that he received regarding room service in Chennai Branch. He read out the complaints and the committee accepted that out of the ten complaints six appeared to be genuine. Hence the committee decided to call for explanation from Sheela Tiwari, the Manager of Chennai branch
The meeting was adjourned at 8.00 p.m. The next meeting of the committee will be on May 6, 2015		

Evaluating the meeting In addition to paying attention to all the aspects discussed in the preceding sections and assigning follow-up tasks, it is important to evaluate the quality of the meeting so that future meetings will be more productive. Given below is a sample of a meeting assessment/evaluation form (Exhibit 9.4). By answering the questions given in this form, the group can measure the success of the meeting and highlight areas that need improvement.

EXHIBIT 9.3 Sample minutes in the informal style

- NA's proposal for recruiting five management trainees was accepted. Advertisement would be placed.
- LD reported that there is no need for a new branch in Nagpur. The committee accepted.
- To carry out RC's proposal for bringing in some innovations in summer travel packages, a threemember committee was formed.
- NA read out the complaints on Bengaluru branch room service. Committee decided to call for explanation from the Bengaluru Manager.

EXHIBIT 9.4 Sample of a meeting assessment form

Please fill in this form by providing the necessary details or encircling your preferred option:

Date: _____

Meeting Objectives _____

Not at all 1

Not really 2

Somewhat 3

Pretty much 4

Very much 5

Not applicable NA

- | | |
|--|--------------|
| 1. Was the meeting necessary? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 2. Was the purpose clear? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 3. Was the meeting manager prepared? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 4. Were the participants prepared? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 5. Were all the needed people present? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 6. Were the participants motivated? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 7. Was the control of the meeting adequate? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 8. Were people involved in discussion? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 9. Was the needed information available? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 10. Were your resources and ideas used? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 11. Were decisions reached on agenda issues? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 12. Was commitment to decisions obtained? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 13. Was the time used efficiently? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 14. Were follow-up work assignments clear? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |
| 15. Were the room and facilities adequate? | 1 2 3 4 5 NA |

Use the back of this form for comments and suggestions